

Shortstop Top Miner Pitcher?

Could it be that the new ace of the U.T.-El Paso mound staff is a shortstop?

Miner coach Andy Cohen is thinking twice about converting junior Herb von Hagen to a pitcher after his performance against powerful Arizona State University last weekend.

Von Hagen came in relief of three Miner hurlers in the third inning of the Sun Devil-Miner series and hurled 6 1-3 innings, allowing only three hits and walking two batters.

"HE HAS MORE poise at pitcher," remarked Cohen, "than he does at any other position. He showed a lot of stuff out there against a great team. He had a lot of confidence in what he was doing."

Von Hagen won't, however, be on the mound when the Miners travel to Las Cruces to face New Mexico State tomorrow at 6 p.m. in a doubleheader. Cohen is expected to start Mark Miller (3-1) and Mike Hilton (1-4).

"We've got to watch out for New Mexico State," Cohen said. "They have improved a lot from when they played here last."

THE AGGIES are 12-31 on the season, the worst record since 1969 when they were 9-27. U.T.-El Paso is 17-20 for the season and is 2-10 in Western Athletic Conference play.

UTEP suffered through defeats of 20-7, 17-2 and 13-3 to ASU this weekend. Miner first baseman Barry Alburtis made his first appearance in two weeks and drove in one run in the first game and two in the second.